

Pavel Durov

A Comprehensive Research Biography

14 July 2026

Contents

1. Introduction
2. Image Gallery
3. Career and Contributions
4. Recent Developments
5. References

Chapter 1

Introduction

Pavel Valeryevich Durov (Russian: **Павел Валерьевич Дуров**; born 10 October 1984) is a technology entrepreneur. He is best known as the chief executive officer (CEO) of Telegram. Durov was born in the Soviet Union, and he co-founded the social networking site VKontakte (VK) in 2006. He was forced out of VK in 2014 following disputes with the company's new owners and increased pressure from Russian authorities, which also led him to leave the country. In 2013, he and his older brother, Nikolai Durov, developed Telegram, and in 2017, they moved to Dubai, United Arab Emirates, where its headquarters are now located. Durov was listed on Forbes's billionaires list in 2023, with an estimated net worth of \$13 billion. His fortune is largely driven by his ownership of Telegram. As of 13 March 2026, Durov was ranked the 588th richest person in the world, with an estimated net worth of \$6.6 billion, according to Forbes. In 2022, he was recognized by Forbes as the richest expat in the United Arab Emirates. In February 2023 Arabian Business named him the most powerful entrepreneur in Dubai. Durov publicly stands for Internet freedom and criticizes the establishment that tries to restrict it. Since 2021, he has held citizenship in Russia, Saint Kitts and Nevis, the United Arab Emirates, and France. On 24 August 2024, Durov was arrested by French police on criminal charges relating to an alleged lack of content moderation on Telegram and refusal to work with police, which allegedly allowed the spread of criminal activities.

Chapter 2

Image Gallery





Chapter 3

Career and Contributions

Early life and education

Durov was born on 10 October 1984 in Leningrad, then Soviet Union, into a Russian family. His father is Valery Durov, a professor of philology. Pavel Durov and his older brother Nikolai spent most of their childhood in Turin, Italy, where their father was employed. Between 2002 and 2006, Durov studied English and Translation at Saint Petersburg State University, where his father worked. Pavel Durov's grandfather Semyon Petrovich Tulyakov fought in World War II. He served in the 65th Infantry Division of the Soviet Red Army, participated in battles on the Leningrad Front at Krasnoborsky and Gatchinsky, and was wounded three times, receiving the Order of the Red Star, the Order of the Patriotic War 2nd degree, and on the 40th Victory Day, the Order of the Great Patriotic War 1st degree. Durov's father Valery Semenovich Durov is a Doctor of Philological Sciences and the author of academic papers. Since 1992, he has been head of the Department of classical philology of the philological faculty of Saint Petersburg State University. In March 2022 Durov wrote that, "On my Mom's side, I trace my family line from Kyiv. Her maiden name is Ukrainian (Ivanenko), and to this day we have many relatives living in Ukraine."

Career

VK

During his university years, Durov created the highly popular forum spbgu.ru. In 2006, he met his former classmate Vyacheslav Mirilashvili in Saint Petersburg. Vyacheslav showed Durov the increasingly popular Facebook, after which the friends decided to create a new Russian social network. Lev Binzumovich Leviev, an Israeli classmate of Vyacheslav Mirilashvili, became the third co-founder. Durov became chief executive officer (CEO) and attracted his older brother Nikolai, a multiple winner of international math and programming competitions including the International Mathematical Olympiad, to develop the site. Durov launched VKontakte for beta testing in September 2006. The following month, the domain name Vkontakte.ru was registered. The new project was incorporated on 19 January 2007 as a Russian private limited company. The user base reached 1 million in July 2007, and 10 million in April 2008. In December 2008 VK overtook rival Odnoklassniki as Russia's most popular social networking service. The company grew to a value of US\$3 billion. In 2011, he was involved in a standoff with the police in Saint Petersburg when the government demanded the removal of opposition politicians' pages after the 2011 election to the Duma; Durov posted a picture of a dog with its tongue out wearing a hoodie, and the police left after an hour when he did not answer the door. In 2012, Durov publicly posted a picture of himself extending his middle finger and calling it his official response to Mail.ru Group's

efforts to buy VK. In December 2013, Durov decided to sell his 12% to Ivan Tavrín (at that time 40% of the shares belonged to Mail.ru Group, and 48% to the United Capital Partners). Later, Tavrín resold these shares to Mail.ru Group.

Telegram

On leaving Russia, he obtained Saint Kitts and Nevis citizenship by donating \$250,000 to the country's Sugar Industry Diversification Foundation and secured \$300 million in cash within Swiss banks. This allowed him to focus on creating his next company, Telegram, an encrypted messaging service. Telegram was briefly headquartered in Berlin and later moved to Dubai. In January 2018, Durov announced that, in a bid to monetize the growing success of Telegram, he was launching the "Gram" cryptocurrency and the Telegram Open Network (TON) platform. It raised a total of \$1.7 billion from investors. However, these ventures were halted by American regulator U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission which argued in court that Gram tokens bypassed U.S. financing laws and should return the money to investors. In 2018, Russia attempted to block Telegram after the company refused to cooperate with Russian security services. A leaked letter by a Federal Security Service employee stated that the block was actually tied to the company's intention to launch the Telegram Open Network. During the attempted block period, the Russian Ministry of Foreign Affairs continued to operate official channels on the app. The block order was lifted in 2020, after two years of block attempts, which the service reportedly evaded using domain fronting. The stated reason was Telegram agreeing to "counter terrorism and extremism" on the platform. Durov said that Telegram became profitable for the first time in 2024, with total revenue over \$1 billion. In 2024, when announcing Telegram had over 1 billion active users, he criticised Meta-owned WhatsApp as "a cheap, watered-down imitation of Telegram" and accused the competitor of using lobbying and PR campaigns to slow down Telegram. In September 2024, Irina Bolgar, who claims to be the mother of three of Durov's children (see below), publicly stated on Instagram that Telegram should be considered jointly acquired property, as the messenger was conceived and developed during their ten-year relationship and they discussed its development together in daily life. Although Bolgar and Durov were never officially married, she noted that some jurisdictions recognize de facto relationships as official marriages for the purposes of property disputes.

2024 arrest and indictment

Durov was arrested on 24 August 2024 at Le Bourget Airport by officers from France's anti-fraud office, which is attached to the French customs authority. He was arrested upon exiting his private jet after landing in France from Azerbaijan. Durov's arrest was based on an arrest warrant issued by the French judicial police as part of a preliminary investigation in relation to 12 suspected violations regarding crime on the Telegram platform. On 28 August, Durov was presented before a prosecutor in court, who formalized 6 charges related to refusal to communicate upon request

from authorized authorities, complicity in criminal activity and provision of cryptology services. On the same day Durov was released from the custody and placed under the judicial supervision, on the conditions that he post 6 million euro bail, be banned from leaving France, and report to the police station twice a week. One of the charges against Durov carries a maximum penalty of 10 years imprisonment and a fine of €500,000. Following the issuance of formal charges, Durov was released on bail and was barred from leaving the territory of France until the case was resolved. It is said that Durov had previously avoided traveling to Europe due to potential legal risks. According to *Le Canard enchaîné*, Durov claimed during his arrest that he had traveled to Paris to dine with French President Emmanuel Macron, which Macron's office denied. Reports also indicate that Durov was on the list of individuals wanted by French authorities, and his arrest was because of his alleged failure to cooperate with judicial officials, including issues related to Telegram's activities. According to French police, criminal activity on Telegram went unfettered through lack of moderators. Natalia Krapiva, a lawyer at the digital rights group Access Now, said that French authorities could try to force Durov to provide Telegram's encryption keys to decrypt private messages, "which Russia has already tried to do in the past". During Durov's arrest and indictment, *The Wall Street Journal* reported that he became a target of a spy operation in 2017. In a joint operation code-named "Purple Music", French spies and the UAE hacked Durov's iPhone. He was targeted because those governments were concerned about the usage of the Telegram app by pro-democracy activists and dissidents. The app also attracted Islamist extremists, drug traffickers and cybercriminals. Despite the hack, Durov received Emirati citizenship in 2021, when the UAE also invested over \$75 million into Telegram. In March 2025, Durov was allowed to leave France and returned to Dubai for a short period.

Personal life

Durov has never been married and has often spoken about his preferences and perceived benefits on living alone. However, according to *The New York Times*, Irina Bolgar provided evidence—including photographs, receipts and a notarized document promising up to 150,000 euros per month in financial support—showing that she and Durov lived together as a couple in Saint Petersburg from 2013 to at least 2017. A former employee of Durov, who spoke to the *Times* on condition of anonymity, corroborated the account, describing the two as a loving couple who lived in an apartment in central St. Petersburg. He moved to the United Arab Emirates in 2017 and lives in Dubai, where Telegram headquarters are located. He was naturalized as an Emirati citizen in February 2021. Durov was naturalized as a French citizen in August 2021, giving him European Union citizenship. *Le Monde* described the naturalisation as "mysterious", since Durov had not resided in France apart from brief visits. *Le Monde* suggested that Durov was naturalised through the rarely used "merit foreigner" procedure that is awarded directly by the French government to people viewed to have contributed exceptionally to France's international influence or international economic relations. Durov officially changed the French version of his name to Paul du Rove. One year later, he told his fans that the passport application had been an

April Fools' joke and that he had forgotten about it, only discovering later that "the application actually got approved and the passport reissued".

Children

It is reported that Durov has 2 children with Daria Bondarenko, a former classmate. It is speculated that one of these children is included in a 2013 photo posted by Durov in late 2024. According to Forbes, Durov met Bondarenko while studying at university; as of 2021, she was living in Barcelona. In 2021, Russian Forbes ranked Durov's children as the sixth-richest heirs in Russia. On 23 July 2024—the day after Durov publicly claimed to have fathered more than 100 children via sperm donation—Irina Bolgar, who lives in Switzerland, contacted Forbes and shared documentation showing that she is the mother of three children by Durov; she also provided a family photo with Durov taken in 2020. Forbes confirmed the authenticity of the documents; Forbes Russia separately verified paternity documents through the Geneva-based translator Bolgar had used when she moved to Switzerland. According to Forbes, Bolgar met Durov in Russia in 2012; they moved to Saint Petersburg, where their three children were born between 2013 and 2017. Because children born outside of marriage were not legally recognized in the UAE at the time, Bolgar and the children remained in Russia when Durov moved to Dubai in 2017. Irina Bolgar and the children continued to spend family time with Pavel Durov after his move to Dubai, meeting in Switzerland, Dubai and other countries; according to Bolgar, the relationship continued until the end of 2022. In March 2023, Bolgar filed a criminal complaint with the Geneva Public Prosecutor's Office alleging that Durov was physically violent toward their youngest son (born September 2017) five times between 2021 and 2022, resulting in injuries that allegedly included a concussion and sleep disorders. Transcripts of messages purportedly exchanged by Bolgar and Durov in Paris in November 2021 and a medical certificate from April 2023 were entered as evidence. The prosecutor initially refused to accept the complaint because it had been filed more than three months after the most recent alleged incident; after Bolgar appealed in May 2023, the court allowed the case to proceed in October 2023. As of August 2024, the case remained ongoing. In April 2023, Bolgar filed a separate civil case in Geneva seeking sole custody. The court granted her exclusive custody and suspended Durov's parental rights in May 2023, a decision reaffirmed in February 2024. Durov did not contest the ruling and appears not to have hired an attorney or responded to the court. Bolgar also filed a civil child support case against Durov in June 2024; she stated that since Durov stopped providing financial support at the beginning of 2023, she had been supporting their children on her monthly salary of 8,000 Swiss francs. According to Forbes, French authorities separately opened an investigation into an alleged act of violence by Durov against the same child in Paris in November 2021. Maylis de Roeck, deputy prosecutor at the Paris prosecutor's office, confirmed the investigation was conducted by OFMIN (the Juvenile Office) and was separate from the Telegram-related case that led to Durov's August 2024 arrest. De Roeck said the office was checking whether there was already a "legal framework" in Switzerland to avoid two investigations into the same incident in different countries.

In 2024, Durov claimed to have fathered more than 100 children via sperm donation in 12 countries since 2010. In 2025, he announced that he wanted to leave his fortune, estimated at US\$17 billion as of 2025, to his 106 children after his death. None of them would be able to receive an inheritance before reaching the age of 30, which all his current children will have reached by June 19, 2055. Durov has spoken publicly about global fertility rates and sperm donation, including during his appearance on the Lex Fridman Podcast. In December 2025, Durov posted in his Telegram channel about creating a sperm donation program.

Views

Durov is a libertarian. He has practiced intermittent fasting and abstains from meat, alcohol, caffeine and recreational drugs. Durov has stated that he maintains an ascetic lifestyle that promotes freedom from personal possessions. At least once, in June 2019, he followed a water-only fasting regimen for at least six days to try to improve his creativity. In 2012, at the age of 27, Durov published manifestos detailing his ideas on improving Russia and donated \$1 million to the Wikimedia Foundation to support Wikipedia. During the 2011–2013 Russian protests, he refused to censor VK accounts used by anti-Putin activists. Durov said that in 2014, he refused to comply with the FSB request to hand over the personal data of Ukrainian protesters and opposition leaders during Euromaidan, "because it would have meant a betrayal of our Ukrainian users. After that, I was fired from the company I founded and was forced to leave Russia. I lost my company and my home, but would do it again – without hesitation." Durov also refused to relinquish data regarding Alexei Navalny's VK page. In 2024, Durov said that Telegram should remain a "neutral platform" and not "a player in geopolitics".

Accolades

Durov has been described as the Mark Zuckerberg of Russia for founding the social networking site VK, which is similar to Facebook. In August 2014, Durov was named by the Nordic Business Forum as the most promising leader under 30 in Northern Europe. In 2017, he was chosen by the WEF Young Global Leaders to join their organization, representing Finland. On 21 June 2018, the Union of Kazakhstan's Journalists bestowed an award on Durov "for his principled position against censorship and the state's interference into citizens' free online correspondence". In 2018, Fortune magazine included Durov in their "40 Under 40" list, an annual ranking of the most influential young people in business. In February 2023, Durov was named the most powerful entrepreneur in Dubai by Arabian Business.

See also

List of Russian billionaires

External links

Short video from The Guardian about Pavel Durov [1] Media related to Pavel Durov at Wikimedia Commons

Chapter 4

Recent Developments and Current Work

Telegram's shortlink domain is back online after day-long suspension - TechCrunch

TechCrunch | 2026-07-14

A domain used by the messaging app Telegram mysteriously dropped offline on Monday, with the app's founder, Pavel Durov, saying in an X post that t.me links had "stopped working." The outage prevented users from accessing the t.me domain shortlink, used by the messaging app to allow users to share one-click links for joining public groups. The domain is now back online, according to the Montenegro-based domain registrar DomainME, which manages the .me top-level domain. "The t.me domain is back online. We will be issuing an official statement shortly," said Predrag Lešić, the chief executive of DomainME, in an email to TechCrunch. In a post on X responding to Durov, DomainME said that Telegram's t.me domain was "on hold due to the OFAC compliance, but it is back online now." OFAC refers to the U.S. Treasury's Office of Foreign Assets Control, which imposes economic sanctions on overseas companies and individuals who pose economic national security risk to the United States. Telegram's t.me domain went offline after a "serverhold" block was put on the domain. A "serverhold" typically means that the domain registrar locked the domain for some reason, which tends to knock the domain offline. The "serverhold" was lifted early on Tuesday, per the site's public internet records. As noted by technologist Jonah Aragon, the domain was suspended on the same day that the U.S. Treasury imposed sanctions on a VPN provider called First VPN, which authorities said was used by cybercriminals to launch ransomware attacks. U.S. authorities shut down the site earlier this year. The Treasury's sanctions listing for First VPN, published Monday, contains a link to the full web address of the VPN provider's public group on Telegram using the shortened t.me domain. It's likely that the domain registrar suspended Telegram's entire t.me domain to comply with the new sanctions, rather than restricting the specific web address that links to the Telegram group in the Treasury's sanctions listing. U.S. companies, including domain registrars, that do not adhere to U.S. sanctions laws can face heavy fines. Another domain used by Telegram, telegram.me, was not listed in the sanctions file and was operational at the time of writing. When you purchase through links in our articles, we may earn a small commission. This doesn't affect our editorial independence. Zack Whittaker is the security editor at TechCrunch. He also authors the weekly cybersecurity newsletter, this week in security. He can be reached via encrypted message at zackwhittaker.1337 on Signal. You can also contact him by email, or to verify outreach, at zack.whittaker@techcrunch.com. Last chance to save up to \$190 on TechCrunch Founder Summit. Join 1,000+ founders and VCs at all stages for real-world scaling insights and connections that move the needle. Savings end June 26, 11:59 p.m. PT. The wildest allegations

in Apple's trade secrets lawsuit against OpenAI Anthropic starts localizing Claude pricing for India, its biggest market after the US

Telegram's t.me Domain Disappears From Global DNS With No Explanation. Pavel Durov Just Found Out on X. - Glitchwire

Glitchwire | 2026-07-14

Every t.me link on the internet stopped working today after Montenegro's .me registry placed Telegram's core shortlink domain on serverHold status, a registry-level action that removes the domain from the global DNS system entirely. The change shows up in WHOIS records with an update timestamp of July 13, 2026. No public explanation has come from Telegram, the .me registry, or Identity Digital, the U.S. company that operates the technical backend for Montenegro's country-code domain. Pavel Durov, Telegram's founder and CEO, acknowledged the outage on X by tagging the .me registry directly: "Hey @domainME, t.me links stopped working. Can you look into it?" The tone suggests Telegram may not have received any advance notice. A serverHold is applied at the registry level, not by the domain registrar. According to ICANN documentation, this status completely excludes a domain from name resolution regardless of how the service's own infrastructure is configured. When a browser tries to resolve t.me, DNS servers now return NXDOMAIN, treating the address as if it simply does not exist. The Telegram app itself continues to function normally. The disruption specifically affects the web-based shortlinks that Telegram has used for years to share channel invites, group links, and user profiles. Every link formatted as t.me/username or t.me/channelname is now dead in browsers worldwide. Notably, the telegram.me domain, which sits in the same .me zone with the same registrar, remains unaffected. This rules out any blanket action against Telegram's entire infrastructure and points to something specific about the t.me registration itself. The .me domain is Montenegro's country-code top-level domain, but it has been marketed globally since 2008 for personal branding and URL shortening. The registry is operated by doMEn, a Montenegro-based joint venture whose partners include Identity Digital and GoDaddy. Google treats .me as a generic extension rather than a geographically targeted one. The arrangement creates an unusual dependency. Telegram built its link-sharing infrastructure around a two-character domain owned by a small Balkan nation, managed by a consortium that includes American companies, and subject to Montenegrin law. WHOIS data shows the t.me domain is registered through GoDaddy with Google's nameservers and carries an expiration date of May 2035. The domain has not lapsed. This disruption arrives during a sensitive period for Durov. French investigators questioned him for a fourth time last week in an ongoing case that dates back to his August 2024 arrest at Le Bourget airport. His attorneys say there is still no evidence supporting the original charges. France lifted his travel ban last November but the investigation remains open. Whether the domain suspension has any connection to legal proceedings is unknown. A serverHold can be applied for various reasons: legal disputes, regulatory compliance orders, internal registry policy

enforcement, or technical errors. Speculation has ranged from government intervention to a simple administrative mistake. The stakes extend beyond Telegram's billion monthly active users. The .me registry also handles shortlinks for PayPal, WordPress, and Meta's family of apps including WhatsApp, Messenger, and Instagram. If registry-level actions can silently knock out a major platform's URL infrastructure without public notice, every company relying on country-code domains for critical services has a new risk to consider. As of publication, neither doME.n nor Identity Digital has issued any statement. Telegram's silence beyond Durov's X post is also notable. Some users report that cached DNS entries may allow t.me links to continue working temporarily, but as caches expire globally, the outage will become universal. This story is developing. Glitchwire will update as more information becomes available.

Telegram links broken after t.me suspension: domain went dark without explanation - Cybernews

Cybernews | 2026-07-14

Telegram links broken after t.me suspension: domain went dark without explanation Cybernews

Pavel Durov Was Questioned in Paris for the Fourth Time in the Telegram Case - SFG Media

SFG Media | 2026-07-09

The Interrogation Lasted More Than Six Hours, While His Lawyers Said There Is No Evidence of Guilt

Two Entrepreneurs Explain Why Telegram Is at the Center of the Internet's Most Important Transformation Yet - entrepreneur.com

entrepreneur.com | 2026-06-26

The technology industry has been dominated by a handful of platforms that control how people communicate, discover content, conduct business, and interact online. While this model created some of the world's most valuable companies, it also concentrated unprecedented influence over the digital lives of billions of people. Entrepreneurs and investors Jason Falovitch and Jonathan Rosen believe a different model is emerging, one built on ownership, direct participation, privacy, and digital sovereignty. Rather than relying on centralized platforms to control digital interactions, they believe the next generation of technology will empower users, creators, developers, and businesses to operate more freely within open ecosystems. In their view, no platform is better positioned to lead that transformation than Telegram. If Steve Jobs was the defining physical

product genius of his generation, Pavel Durov is the defining digital product genius of his. Jobs transformed the devices people used to communicate. Durov is transforming the digital networks through which people communicate. What began as a messaging application has evolved into one of the world's most powerful digital and social ecosystems. With more than 1 billion monthly active users, more than 500 million daily active users, and 2.5 million new users joining every day, Telegram has become a platform where communication, commerce, payments, blockchain, communities, artificial intelligence, and digital ownership increasingly converge. Today, it ranks among the 5 largest apps in the world and has become a destination for users seeking greater privacy, freedom of expression, and control over their digital lives. Few technology companies have successfully combined such scale, utility, and growth. While Telegram is often compared to WhatsApp, the comparison increasingly feels outdated. WhatsApp remains a messaging application operating within Meta's ecosystem, where user data, advertising interests, and broader corporate objectives inevitably influence the platform's direction. Telegram, by contrast, has evolved into one of the world's most comprehensive digital ecosystems, built around privacy, freedom, and user autonomy. The two platforms are no longer competing on the same playing field. Telegram's faster growth reflects a shift toward platforms that offer greater freedom, innovation, and opportunity. Increasingly, users are not choosing between two messaging apps. They are choosing between a platform built for the internet of the past and one built for the internet of the future. The numbers alone are difficult to ignore. Telegram continues to grow at a pace rarely seen among platforms of its size, guided by the long-term vision of its sole shareholder and founder, Pavel Durov, one of the most influential product designers and technology leaders of the digital era. Unlike many of the world's largest technology companies, which are often shaped by competing corporate interests and shareholder pressures, Telegram remains one of the few global platforms still driven by a founder's vision rather than financial engineering, allowing it to prioritize innovation, user freedom, privacy, and long-term value creation above short-term profit maximization. This commitment has not come without consequence. Over the past decade, Durov has repeatedly found himself at the center of battles over privacy, censorship, surveillance, and government access to digital communications, including high-profile disputes with authorities in Russia, France, and numerous other jurisdictions. His experience mirrors a broader trend confronting many of the world's most influential technology leaders. Elon Musk, through his ownership of X, Starlink, and other ventures, has increasingly found himself in direct conflict with governments seeking greater influence over digital infrastructure and public discourse. Across Europe in particular, regulators have intensified efforts to impose new content moderation requirements, platform accountability standards, and speech-related regulations on large technology platforms. Musk has openly challenged many of these initiatives, arguing that they risk eroding free expression and concentrating excessive power in the hands of government authorities and unelected regulators. While Musk and Durov operate very different businesses, they have become emblematic of the same underlying debate: who ultimately controls the digital public square. Both have resisted demands they believe compromise user autonomy, privacy, or freedom of expression. Both have

faced significant political, legal, and regulatory pressure as a result. And both have become increasingly controversial figures precisely because they are willing to challenge governments on issues that most technology companies prefer to avoid. It is perhaps no coincidence that two of the most prominent advocates for digital freedom have increasingly found themselves in the crosshairs of regulators around the world. As governments seek greater oversight of online platforms and digital communications, the conflicts surrounding Musk and Durov are not merely disputes between individuals and regulators. They are defining battles over the future relationship between citizens, governments, and the technologies that increasingly shape modern life. While much of the technology industry remains focused on the platforms that defined the last decade, Falovitch and Rosen believe Telegram is defining the future. In their view, Telegram is no longer just a technology company or a messaging platform. It is becoming a foundational layer of the modern internet and a blueprint for a freer, more open, and more sovereign digital world where individuals, not governments or institutions, hold the power.

Telegram Founder Pavel Durov Questioned for Fourth Time in Ongoing French Criminal Probe - CryptoRank

CryptoRank | 2026-07-09

Telegram founder Pavel Durov was questioned for a fourth time by French investigating judges on July 8, 2026, spending more than six hours in Paris; he has been formally charged since 2024 over alleged failures to moderate illegal content and to cooperate with law enforcement. Durov's lawyers say prosecutors presented no evidence and Telegram says cooperation has improved but the criminal probe remains ongoing, creating regulatory and security overhang risks for Telegram-related crypto projects, token launches and broader adoption. Telegram founder Pavel Durov has been questioned for a fourth time by French investigating judges as authorities continue their criminal investigation into the messaging platform. According to sources , Durov spent more than six hours answering questions in Paris on Wednesday. It was his fourth interrogation since he was formally charged in 2024. The case focuses on allegations that Telegram failed to properly moderate illegal content and cooperate with law enforcement. Read The Full Article Telegram Founder Pavel Durov Questioned for Fourth Time in Ongoing French Criminal Probe On Coin Edition .

Telegram founder Durov says India has 'punished' more than 150 million people by banning Telegram - Reuters

Reuters | 2026-06-16

Telegram founder Durov says India has 'punished' more than 150 million people by banning Telegram Reuters

Pavel Durov Gifts \$12,000 Worth of Plush Pepe NFT to a Telegram Designer - Yahoo Finance

Yahoo Finance | 2026-06-27

Telegram founder Pavel Durov purchased Plush Pepe #834 for 7,500 Gram (GRAM) on The Open Network, then transferred the NFT to Adler Toberg, a designer linked to Telegram's interface and gift system. The acquisition marks Durov's third confirmed purchase of a TON collectible in just over six months. He added his first Plush Pepe in December 2025, then picked up a Telegram Gift NFT in January 2026. Together, the moves reflect deliberate and ongoing personal engagement with the digital asset layer Telegram continues to build. Plush Pepes are Telegram's official collectibles series, issued natively on The Open Network (TON). At GRAM's current price of \$1.55, the 7,500 GRAM spent on Plush Pepe #834 comes to roughly \$11,625. The specific piece is the Donatello model, a 1% rarity variant, with a Bell Pepper symbol (0.5%) and a Navy Blue backdrop (2%). Of the 2,861 Donatello editions, 2,825 have found owners. TON development has accelerated alongside the demand for collectibles. A major protocol upgrade made TON 10 times faster, cutting transaction times to sub-second finality. On the product side, GOAT Gaming's Underground Pepe moved Plush Pepes beyond profile accessories. The project turned them into active gaming assets, complete with a dedicated rewards currency. Secondary market activity has also expanded. A Telegram username sold for 500,000 USDT in a recent TON NFT resale, reflecting strong demand for Telegram-native assets. The TON Blockchain X account responded to Durov's purchase with a dry piece of humor. It expressed hope that he would pass the NFT along to a Telegram intern as a workplace bonus. The joke turned out to be close to the truth. Durov transferred Plush Pepe #834 directly to Adler Toberg, a designer known for his work on Telegram's interface and gift system. Toberg has previously made public statements about the direction of Telegram's collectibles program, including the cadence of new gift releases. The transfer points to something real. Within the Telegram ecosystem, collectibles now carry social weight as markers of community standing. Durov's decision to give a high-value NFT to a member of his team reinforces that dynamic. His role as Telegram's CEO makes each on-chain move a visible signal across the network. The token itself also changed course this year. GRAM was rebranded from Toncoin following an 81% governance vote, reverting to the name from Telegram's original 2018 whitepaper. The chain also broadened its reach through Apple Watch integration and a wider ecosystem push. Read the Original story Pavel Durov Gifts \$12,000 Worth of Plush Pepe NFT to a Telegram Designer by Phil Haunhorst at beincrypto.com

TON Becomes Gram: Why Pavel Durov Rebranded the Coin — And What It Means for the Future of Telegram Crypto - Bitcoin Foundation

Bitcoin Foundation | 2026-06-02

Out of nowhere, TONcoin takes a twist. Now it's called Gram, according to Pavel Durov's update . Slowly swapping the name, he says, though the network keeps the TON title. A blast from the past surfaces – Gram once echoed through early crypto dreams. This shift tugs back toward Telegram's first blueprint. Familiar echoes rise as the old meaning finds new footing. Right away, folks investing in projects started wondering. Could this be another digital coin showing up out of nowhere? Might people have to exchange their current holdings? Has Telegram stepped back in to run things directly once more? Even so, the bigger puzzle remains – how will renaming Gram reshape what comes next for Telegram's crypto plans and its wider web of connected tech? What matters most? Toncoin becoming Gram isn't about launching another coin. Telegram plus TON says it's just a rename – same token, different label. Your wallet amount stays put. Smart contracts keep working as before. Staked coins won't move. NFT holdings stay intact. The network itself runs without tweaks. Eventually, those holding TON might notice it shown as Gram inside apps, wallets, or trading platforms. What changes is just the name you see – not what they own. Read more: [Top 5 TON Ecosystem Projects in 2026: Best TON Crypto to Buy, DeFi Leaders & Telegram Gems](#) Even if the money shifts shape, the system stays put. Running under The Open Network name, TON blockchain keeps moving forward. What sets this apart fits into how the project positions itself overall. Running underneath it all is still the TON blockchain, yet the money used on it now goes by the name Gram. Other systems in the crypto space work much the same way. Take Ethereum – that's the platform, but the coins are called ETH ▲ \$1,761.17 . Solana operates like that too: one name for the tech, another for its digital asset. A shift like that seems to be taking shape on Telegram. Three weeks should cover it, says Pavel Durov. Rolling out step by step, wallets get updated first, then exchanges follow along. Explorers see changes soon after, while apps in the ecosystem adjust over time. Each piece moves at its own pace, yet fits the timeline. This step-by-step method lowers interference while offering companies a chance to adjust their platforms slowly. Not rushed, they can revise both connections and market tools at ease. ■■ Nothing changes except the name and ticker. No swap, no migration, no action needed. Any site asking you to "claim GRAM ▼ \$1.69 " or "migrate TON" is fraudulent and you should not interact with them in any way. One thing remains clear – no switching of tokens will happen. Still, the setup remains unchanged on that front. Most folks won't see a difference in their holdings. Just the label shifts, nothing underneath. Account details stay put. Staked amounts? Still locked where they were. The rename skips the usual chaos seen when coins relaunch. Fewer moving parts means fewer things breaking. Back in 2018 lies the clue to Gram's importance for investors. Starting off, Telegram introduced what they called the Telegram Open Network, aiming to build a worldwide blockchain system tied into their chat service. Powering transactions, apps, and online features within that space was meant to be a coin named Gram. The idea took shape slowly, shaped by early plans and tech goals. Built right in, this digital money had a purpose – moving value where users interacted most. Back then, Telegram pulled in around 1.7 billion dollars via private token rounds – ranking among crypto's biggest money hauls ever. Facing heat from regulators, the project stumbled after the SEC claimed selling Grams was like issuing unapproved securities. Though designed as utility tokens, authorities saw them differently. What looked like a

tech rollout turned into a legal standoff overnight. Back then, in 2019, a court order stopped the token rollout cold. Because of the fight in court, Telegram scrapped its first launch strategy. Later on, once things were sorted out with the authorities in 2020, Telegram pulled back completely. Out went the Gram token; instead, people began using Toncoin to represent what belongs to the network now. A fresh name drew a line between the work and past courtroom ties, yet kept progress moving through self-run guidance. After Telegram stepped back, independent builders kept expanding the system. Oversight later shifted to the TON Foundation, with Toncoin settling into place as the main digital money of the platform. Back then, TON shifted – no longer just Telegram's project, but shaped by its users. A quiet handover, really, one step at a time. Back to where it started – that's how Durov frames the move. From the first papers on TON, one thing stayed clear: the coin had a name, Gram. Not now invented, just remembered. This shift tugs the present toward those early blueprints, quietly aligning what is with what was. Step four in the seven-part strategy has arrived, reshaping where things are headed – it's tied to the MTONGA path, which stands for Make TON Great Again. Reintroducing Gram marks this phase, quietly slotting into a broader sequence already in motion. Just hit some big points on the path forward – network speed got a boost, costs went down, plus Telegram is now more connected than before. A clearer brand setup comes out of this choice, too. Still, The Open Network holds up the base. On top of it, Gram moves into users' hands as money. Because of this split, handling ads, transactions, and potentially wider use will be simpler down the road. What stands out now is how much more Telegram matters. Back in January, Durov revealed Telegram's plan to step into the top validator role on the network. This shift moved it into what had once been the core function of the TON Foundation. Now, control leans more heavily toward the app itself rather than the original group behind the protocol. Some see the Gram rename as hinting at tighter ties with Telegram ahead. A shift many link to broader moves inside the messaging platform's ecosystem lately. Right now, details point to tokenomics staying just like they are. The way the supply works should hold steady, along with how staking runs. Validator payouts likely won't shift either. The network economic patterns appear set to follow the past behavior. This shift moves the name more than it changes how money works. Gram's new name will slowly appear on wallets and trading platforms. Even though the token has a fresh label, staking keeps running since the network itself hasn't shifted at all. Even if updates seem clear, checking exchange notices helps verify when changes actually go live. Gram balances show up without any action needed. So far, there's no official move or switch required. The tokens people have just carried forward are now called by another term. Related: [Top 5 DEX Wallets in 2026: Which Crypto Wallet Is Best for DeFi and Swaps?](#) Years go by, and the new name might stick better in people's minds. Not many digital currency ideas that have ever been launched are remembered like Gram is. What once started quietly now stands out more than most expected. Back then, ties could still pull in interest – this time from everyday buyers, sometimes big funds too. Now shaping up as a core part of how things run, Telegram takes deeper root. With Durov's confirmation comes the shift – it won't just join but lead, stepping into the biggest validating role ahead. Now speed matters more than ever on the TON blockchain. Telegram says things move faster these days, yet cost far less per

transfer. For Gram to handle everyday transactions, these upgrades matter a lot. Without them, keeping up might be tough. Even so, progress here shapes what comes next. Without change, scaling feels out of reach. Every shift counts when regular users start relying on it. Still pushing growth across the platform, Telegram Mini Apps hold steady as a key force. A quiet engine behind user expansion, these tools keep shaping how people interact daily. Not flashy, yet deeply embedded in routines. Their reach grows without fanfare, pulling more into the fold through utility alone. Out there, millions are using blockchain apps right within Telegram. Few rival platforms come close to offering that kind of reach. Some folks putting money into markets think that's where things are headed over time. A single unified Gram token might handle person-to-person exchanges, online buying, payouts to creators, recurring memberships, and internal app features throughout Telegram's network. Fresh momentum built up after investors saw the overhaul as a sign that Telegram was stepping in more deeply. Right away, shares of TON climbed sharply, fueled by bets on wider use down the line. Still, optimism holds strong. The Gram label sticks in people's minds – linked tightly to Telegram's early days – making it feel weightier than Toncoin for plenty who back the project. Despite

Telegram's t.me domain stops working; Pavel Durov asks domain registry to look into it - MediaNama

MediaNama | 2026-07-14

Telegram's short-link domain, t.me, stopped resolving on July 13, 2026. Links such as t.me/[username], t.me/[channelname], and group invite links stopped opening in web browsers. "Hey @domainME, t.me links stopped working. Can you look into it?" Telegram founder Pavel Durov noticed the issue and posted on X, tagging the .me domain registry. At the time of writing this report, there is no official explanation from either Telegram or the .me registry. What is a .ME domain? The .ME domain is the internet address for Montenegro, a small Mediterranean country with about 600,000 people. This country code top-level domain (ccTLD) doesn't have any restrictions on who can use the domain. How did we check the status of the t.me domain? To verify the domain's status, using Claude, we ran two standard checks that anyone can use to inspect a domain's registration records. What we found: Both Whois and RDAP lookup checks resulted in t.me currently carrying a "server hold" status. This is a flag applied by the domain registry and not by Telegram or GoDaddy, Telegram's domain registrar. Because the domain appears to be on registry hold, using a VPN would generally not bypass the issue. The RDAP record also showed that the domain details were last updated on July 13, 2026, which roughly coincides with when Pavel Durov highlighted the issue on X. He posted on Jul 14, 2026, at 6:39 AM IST; over 5 hours later, the domain update was logged. A couple of users on X pointed out the US Department of the Treasury's Office of Foreign Assets Control's press release on Specially Designated Nationals (SDN). In that press release , which is also published on the same day as the t.me domain's last log was registered (13 July), First VPN Service is blacklisted. According to

the FBI's May 2026 notice on First VPN Service, it was reportedly used by at least 25 ransomware groups. Among the URLs and email addresses specified under First VPN Service, t.me/FirstVPNService is one of them. However, there is no official confirmation that the OFAC designation is related to the registry action affecting t.me. Throwback: In August 2025, MediaNama reported that the t.me domain was blocked on BSNL networks along with a few legitimate websites. Read MediaNama's full report [here](#) .

References

- 1 https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Pavel_Durov
- 2 <https://techcrunch.com/2026/07/14/telegrams-shortlink-domain-is-back-online-after-day-long-suspension/>
- 3 <https://glitchwire.com/news/telegrams-tme-domain-disappears-from-global-dns-with-no-explanation-pavel-durov/>
- 4 <https://cybernews.com/security/telegram-links-broken-after-domain-outage/>
- 5 <https://sfg.media/en/a/pavel-durov-fourth-questioning-paris-telegram-case/>
- 6 <https://www.entrepreneur.com/business-news/tech/why-telegram-is-at-the-center-of-the-internets-most-important-transformation-yet>
- 7 <https://cryptorank.io/news/feed/6ea9a-telegram-founder-pavel-durov-questioned-for-fourth-time-in-ongoing-french-criminal-probe>
- 8 <https://www.reuters.com/world/india/telegram-founder-durov-says-india-has-punished-more-than-150-million-people-by-2026-06-16/>
- 9 <https://beincrypto.com/pavel-durov-plush-pepe-nft-gram-ton/>
- 10 <https://bitcoinfoundation.org/news/altcoins/ton-becomes-gram-why-pavel-durov-rebranded-the-coin-and-what-it-means-for-the-future-of-telegram-crypto/>
- 11 <https://www.medianama.com/2026/07/223-telegrams-t-me-domain-stops-working-pavel-durov-asks-domain-registry/>